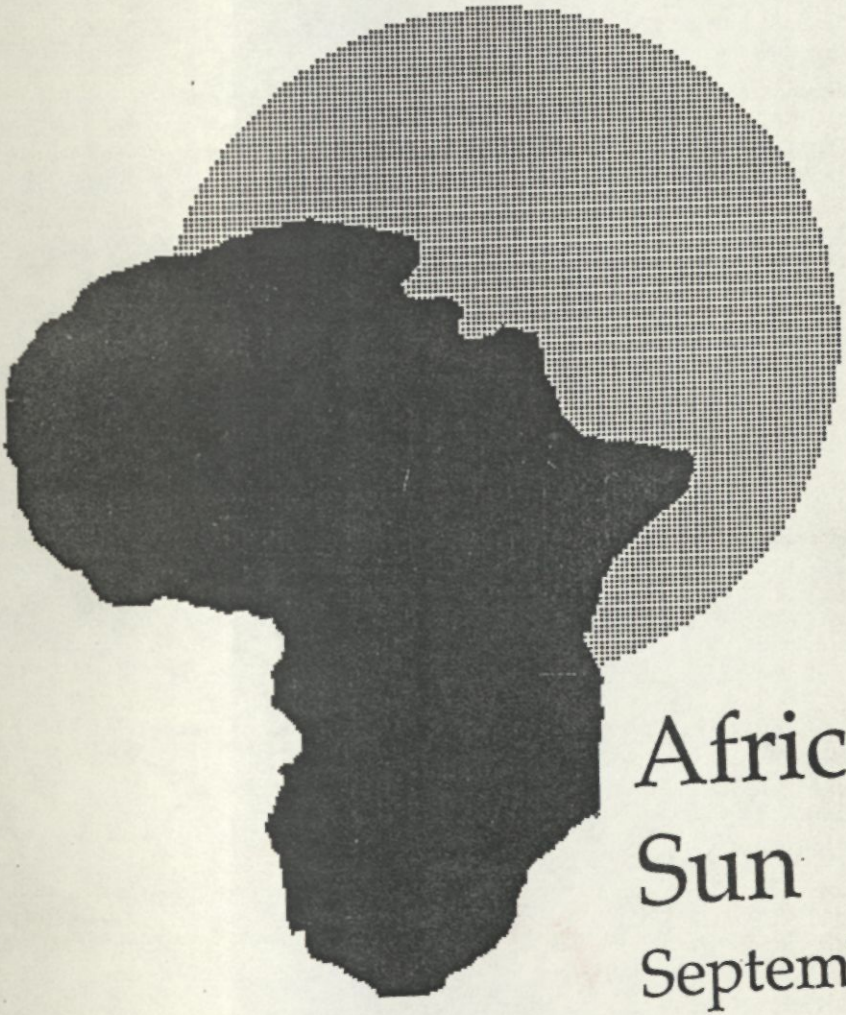

# African Sun

September 1991

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# HISTORICAL EVENTS IN THE MONTH-SEPTEMBER

1st, 1975-- General Daniel "Chappie" James Jr. named commander-in-chief of the North American Air Defense Command and promoted to rank of four-star general.

2nd, 1975-- Joseph W. Hatchett sworn in as first Black supreme court justice in the South in the twentieth century.

9th, 1971-- Inmates of Attica State Correctional Facility in Attica, N.Y. seized the building and held several guards hostage. They issued a list of fifteen demands calling for an end to censorship of reading material, coverage by the state minimum wage law, better food, and no reprisals for the revolt. The takeover ended four days later when the state commissioner of corrections ordered an air and ground assault which left thirty-two prisoners and ten guards dead. Investigations later showed that nine of the ten guards were killed by the storming party. Twenty years after the revolt that led to prison reform nation wide, current inmates of Attica are still calling for improved conditions.

17th, 1861--The first day school for freedmen was opened in Fortress Monroe, VA under the instruction of a Black teacher, Mary Peake.

18th, 1990--George Houston Bass, born April 23, 1938, died. Bass was a highly respected professor at Brown since 1970. Bass founded the Rites and Reason theater located in Churchill House in 1970 (see Rites and Reason), help to create the Langston Hughes Center for the Arts in Providence, and was described as unique and positive in his ability to articulate our culture. The past year has left Brown with a void that will never be filled and Bass is missed by all who knew him.

19th, 1890--Tuskegee Institute, founded by Booker T. Washington, was opened in Tuskegee, Alabama.

21st, 1872--John Henry Conyers of South Carolina became the first Black student at Annapolis Naval Academy.

22nd, 1960--Mali proclaimed independent of French colonial rule.

24th & 25th, 1957--Nine Black students had to be escorted by soldiers after President Eisenhower ordered federal troops to prevent interference with school integration at Central High School in Little Rock, Arkansas.

## THURGOOD MARSHALL

oon the nation will lose its first and to date its only Black Su-
reme Court justice (we'll see what happens with Clarence Tho-
nas). Before we get too involved in the hype of the confirmation
f a controversial Black nominee, let's not forget a man who has
nade a tremendous impact on the policies of the United States.
'hurgood Marshall became director of the NAACP Legal Defense
'und in 1950 after the death of Charles Houston. Marshall was
ounsel for three landmark cases in June of 1950 which challenged
he legal foundations of segregation. Later, Marshall was counsel
n the landmark case of Brown vs. the Board of Education of
'opeka in 1954 which declared segregation in public schools
nconstitutional. President John Kennedy appointed Marshall to
he United States circuit court in New York in 1961, and President
Lyndon Johnson appointed Marshall to be solicitor general in 1965.
Marshall was appointed to the Supreme Court by President John-
son on June 13, 1967 and was confirmed by the Senate on August
30th. There will be other Black Justices, but there will never be
another Thurgood Marshall. He will not, can not be forgotten.

NEWS

## CAPITAL PUNISHMENT

Warren McCleskey was executed Thursday morning, September 26 at approximately 3 a.m. despite numerous pleas to the Supreme Court. As reported by the New York Times, McCleskey, an African-American factory worker was executed for the 1978 murder conviction of a white police officer during an attempted robbery in Jackson, Georgia. It was last April when the Court voted six to three to reject McCleskey's claim that his sentence was tainted by information withheld from the jury. The Court's justification was that he failed to make the claim on the first habeas corpus petition, eventhough two of the jurors in McCleskey's original case stated they would change their decisions upon learning that a main witness was a police informant. Much of the evidence in the case was circumstantial. McCleskey's case became a landmark decision when the highly conservative Supreme Court

affirmed the legality of the death penalty with a five to four vote in 1987. McCleskey admitted to being involved with the robbery, but never admitted to firing the gun that led to the officer's death. Statistics show there is a higher frequency of death sentences given to persons convicted of killing whites than to those sentenced to die for killing Blacks (see African Sun, May, 1991). Only a few people will ever really know who fired the fatal shot ending the officer's life, but one does know that whomever was responsible, a man's life is gone--forever.

## LACK OF OCCUPATIONAL SAFETY KILLS 25

On September 3rd, twenty-five people died and another fifty-five were left injured in a senseless fire in a Hamlet, North Carolina chicken processing plant. Victims died from smoke inhalation while making a desperate search for exits to escape from the blazing plant. According to the AFL-CIO News, prior to the scramble to flee the burning building, the plant manager at Imperial Food Products stated, "I don't care, just get it fixed--we're losing money," referring to a damaged, and potentially dangerous hydraulic line. Unfortunately, the hydraulic line to the twenty-six foot long deep-fat fryer ruptured allowing fluid to leak, and thereby catching fire. The large number of deaths was not necessarily due to the outbreak of the fire, but rather to the hazardous working conditions in the plant. Although there were frequent USDA inspections which were concerned with the quality of the chickens, an appearance was never made by the Occupational Safety and Health program. Thus, conditions in the plant were extremely hazardous. The plant manager's lack of concern for the workers' safety was clear as *emergency exit doors were locked to prevent employees from stealing*! Many of the employees were Black women--single parents, and all the workers were poor. What now of the numerous children left without mothers? Although it is very important that the food we eat be inspected for quality, it is equally important that the same effort be put into the establishment of safe working conditions . What of this capitalist society when human lives are valued less than the *possibility* of stolen *poultry*?

## JAZZ GREAT MILES DAVIS PASSES ON

On Saturday, September 28th, the world lost one of its best jazz musicians. Born May 25, 1926 in Alton, Illinois, Mr. Miles Davis was famous for his trumpet playing and his abilities to change his style every few years branching off to play various styles of jazz including bebop, hard-bop, cool, jazz rock, and jazz funk. His career included playing with other jazz greats such as Coleman Hawkins, Sonny Rollins, Dizzie Gillespie, Charlie Parker, Thelonious Monk, and John Coltrane. Miles Davis died in St. John's Hospital in Santa Monica, CA after spending two weeks there. The cause of death, according to the New York Times, was pneumonia, respiratory failure, and stroke. Mr. Davis is survived by his three children- Cheryl Anne, Gregory, and Miles- and grand-children.

## 23 YEAR-OLD LONG JUMP RECORD BROKEN

Mike Powell jumped 29' 4.5" to beat Bob Beamon's twenty-three year old long jump record of 29' 2.5". Although jumper/sprinter Carl Lewis had not been beaten by Powell in 15 attempts and remained unbeaten in sixty-five competitions, Powell was able to capture the record in Tokyo. His assurance of breaking the record was apparent even a day prior to the long jump finals. According to Sports Illustrated, he even signed autographs before the finals with "8.95?" which is the metric measurement for 29' 4.5"

## RITES AND REASON "BACK ON THE BLOCK" FOR BROWN'S BLACK STUDENTS

Elmo Terry-Morgan ('74), the Artistic Director of Rites and Reason Theater, plans to carry on the traditions of the company started by George Houston Bass. Bass was the former Artistic Director who

died in September, 1990.

Terry-Morgan is currently entering into a partnership with the George Houston Bass Kulcha Kollectiv in order to establish a Friday Night Cabaret, a place where students can go, spontaneously create and appreciate African-American culture. He views the Cabaret as a "party with substance."

He is also interested in linking with Black, Latino, Asian, Lesbian/Gay and other cultural groups on campus. His office is room 207B in Churchill House and his extension is 863-1707. The number to Rites and Reason is 863-3558.

Terry-Morgan has had intimate experience with Rites and Reason in th past. In 1970 when George Houston Bass founded Rites and Reason Theater in response to a vocal Black student community, Terry-Morgan was a member of the freshman class. He experienced an era when Rites and Reason was driven by *students*, and intends on restoring that student voice.

He noticed that input from community and professional circles has "drowned out" the students' voice. Terry-Morgan stated, "Mechanisms to facilitate student involvement were never put into place." He recognizes what needs to be done is to ensure an inlet for students: "It is a matter of setting up system of communication that will inform students about Rites and Reason's focus from the time they attend the Third World Transition Program or the general freshman orientation."

At Rites and Reason Theater, research is an integral part of the play-writing and play-producing process. This unique component combines the scholar and the artist in an Afrocentric environment. The artistic expressions created are not adornments, but necessities which evolve as African-American reality changes. In 1970, Bass's mission was to get away from the "pathology art" in which most Black plays had similar character types and plots set in urban settings. Terry-Morgan, realizing this as well, says: "We can't keep reinventing A Raisin in the Sun."

## FAREWELL TO CHAPLIN WIGGINS

Former Associate Chaplin Daphne Wiggins delivered her last Brown sermon Sunday, September 29th. She was at Brown for six years, and while here worked with the Society Organized Against Racism, advisory committees with the Women's Peer Counseling Program, an the Sarah Doyle Women's Center. She was the worship leader of the Evening Service based in the Black Evangelical Tradition. Due to University budget cuts, her position will be partially filled by an intern to be announced theChaplain's Office later. She will be missed by faculty and students alike who were greatly impacted by her presence, as she is now pursuing her docto ate at Emory University in Atlanta. We hate to see her go, but wish her the be and will keep her in our prayers.

## THOUGHTS & OPINIONS

### Join This Clique Today

Attention all African-American students of Brown University, register today for one of the Black community's preeminent attractions - social cliques. That's right, you too can belong to one of the following unofficial but obvious Black coteries:

*The Fly Girl Crew* - For those ladies who desire the utmost in cliquish exclusivity, look no further. Chill in campus dining halls with fellow Crew members and snootily ignore anyone who doesn't measure up to Crew standards of beauty and chic. Pretend you're attending a Black college by wearing the latest in trendy Black fashions, complemented by excessive cosmetic application, to classes, meals, and social gatherings. Join a sorority and emit piercing screeches at Black Greek functions. No homely sisters please.

*Hard Homies*, Inc. - Unquestionably the favorite choice of the African-American male in search of the hard-hitting, NWA-worshipping, brothers-from-around-the-way subculture at Brown. The Homies guarantee that their members will embody the ultimate in ebony manliness, defined of course by none other than the Homies themselves. Benefits include the annual prey on freshmen women. Join a fraternity and interrupt dancing at Black Greek parties by stomping and barking with the fellas. Sit with other Homies in campus cafeterias and become the conceited objects of every sister's desire. Athletic ability encouraged. No punk mother fuckers please.

*The Commoners* - Females who fail or refuse to exhibit the vanity required for the Fly Girl Crew dominate this particular sect. Activities include minimal to moderate participation in Black Greek activities and spiting members of the Fly Girl Crew. Men are also members, especially those who resemble Malcolm Jamal Warner rather than Ice Cube (The Homies prototype). Average appearance,

The African Sun would like to extend a welcome to the Sisters and Brothers of the Class of 1995.

PALOMA ADAMS
DELIA ALEXANDER
JOSEPH ALSTON
KRYSTAL APPIAH
DEBORAH ARCHER
LAMBERT ARNOLD
CHARENE ARTHUR
MATTHEW BIRNEL
MALAIKA BOYD
KIPP BRADFORD
STEFAN BRATHWAITE
EDWARD BROCKENBROUGH
MELANDEE BROWN
TYRONE BROWN
CARMA BURNETTE
KELVIN CANADY
ALAN COLE
CYLTON COLLYMORE
GBAQYEE COOPER
MICHELLE CREARY
TRISHA DALEY
DEILA DAVIS
AMANDA DERRYCK
NWAMAEGWU DURU
CHANDLER EVANS
ARTHUR EVERETT
DEVIN FEHELY
DANIEL FOREMAN
RAYMOND FRASER
TIFFANI GAVIN
OLUFUNMILAYO GITTENS
PETER GOURDINE
JOSEPH GRANT
DAWIT HAILE
BRIAN JONES
KRISTINA JONES
ADJOA JONES DE ALMEIDA
SHANI KING
JOEL KOPLIK
KHARY LAZARRE-WHITE
MARVIN LEE
MARKETA WILLS
JACQUES LOUIS
KARL LOZANNE
JAMIE MACBETH
ANTHONY MAYS
PRENTICE MCCULLOUGH
DESMA MITCHELL
DENA MONTAGUE
ENVALL MORGAN
JOELLE MURCHISON
CHRISTOPHER MYERS
MALIK NAGEL
GBEKELEOLVUA OLOWE
JEFFREY PATTERSON
MICHELE PIERRE-LOUIS
KENDRA PROCTOR
ABIGAIL RAMSAY
BLAYR ROBERTSON
AMBER RUTLAND
MILDA SAUNDERS
GINA SCHAROUN
CORA SHAW
SHANNON SIMON
STEPHEN SMITH
EUGENE SMITH
TANYA SOUTHERLAND
DAVE JOHN SOVERALL
MICHELLE SPEIGHT
ALEXIS STODGHILL
MARK STREAMS
JYLL TAYLOR
WELELA TEREFFE
KINA THOMAS
TRACY TUCKER
TEZETA TULLOCH
KAYWATTIE TULSHI
MARGO VASSAR
SIOVAHN WALKER
JASON WARWIN
EBONYA WASHINGTON
HANAKO WILLIAMS
PORTIA WILLIAMS
ELIZABETH WILLIAMSON

We are delighted that you chose Brown and look forward to working with such beautiful, talented, enthusiastic, and bright **Black** students.

"Youth"

We have to-morrow
Bright before us
Like a flame

Yesterday, a night-gone thing
A sun-down name

And dawn to-day
Broad arch above the road we came,
We march!

—Langston Hughes

LETTER TO THE CLASS OF 1995

The best of wishes for an educationally enriched and enjoyable time at Brown. Remember your time here can make a vast difference for future Black students at Brown. So while doing your best to assure your academic success and happiness here, look out for the well-being of those Black students who hope to follow in your foot steps and take steps to assure that their presence will be possible. Fighting for policies such as need-blind admissions and the Investment in Diversity Scholarship Fund can directly affect the rate of admissions and matriculation of Black students to Brown. Without the hard work and sacrifices of our predecessors--like the Black women of Pembroke College who initiated the walkout of 1968 and others throughout the years--our numbers would be worse than they are at present. The University still has not met the percentages it agreed to through the years, which is why we must continue to struggle to assure that the University keeps its commitments to the Black as well as Third World community and students receiving financial aid. You have four years, and as MacArthur White, Brown Class of '91, used to say, "Milk it for all its worth!"

studious work habits, positions with UFS, and a belief in God are optional but encouraged.

Feel the fellowship of an individual clique within Brown's Black community. Enjoy the lack of unity afforded by such a segmented African-American population. Join your clique today!

The above satire was an attempt to address a problem in the Black community here at Brown - factionalism. Since this is a **Black** concern, I am addressing this issue in a **Black** publication, as opposed to sentencing this topic to the distortion and manipulation of the general media. It is imperative that Black people resolve Black concerns within the Black community. Otherwise, our intraracial disputes hang as banners of ethnic weakness for the world to ridicule and exploit.

The exaggerated presentation of the first half of this article was employed in hopes of directing attention to an insidious virus infecting Brown's Black community: a lack of unity manifested in the form of cliques. Without question, people are free to associate with whomever they choose. Forming a core network of relationships, developing strong ties to that special group of friends who understand and support you like no one else can, is by all means a positive process; without it, many would fall victim to the pressures of university life. It's the introduction of exclusivity that taints this collegiate kinship. Rejecting fellow Blacks who try to momentarily tap into this bond is selfish, hoarding the bond from others, and thus unnatural, going against communal Afrocentric traditions.

Furthermore, as African-Americans on a predominantly white campus, as a people whose primary means for survival in such an environment has always been the mutual respect and trust between all Brothers and Sisters, cliques subjugate us to the will of the powers that be. Our combative strength against injustice is mitigated by the absence of racial cohesiveness. We are burdened not only by institutional prejudices, but also by the irrational and destructive biases of our own kind.

Cliques go beyond the freedom of social selectivity. They become a tool for impeding our intrinsic bond as people of African descent, a force too precious to jeopardize over the trivial differences on which cliques are founded. What difference does it make if a brother prefers stomping at a party or acting in a play? Or if a sister's vocal trademark is a piercing shrill rather than a gospel hymn? These variations in personal style only add to the fundamental determinants of our identity - the shared recognition and pride of our African heritage. Our unique individualities should compliment our heritage, not detract from it.

So the next time you are walking across campus, or sitting at a table in VW or the Ratty, try acknowledging an unfamiliar Black face. Receiving recognition from another African-American reaffirms one's identification with, one's sense of belonging to, the Black community at Brown, the **only** clique that needs to exist. Join this clique today.

--A Concerned Brother

## *AFRICAN*-AMERICAN?

How realistic is it for us to claim a cultural connection to our African ancestry? How can we - many of us four or more generations removed from our ancestors from Africa - claim ties to a history of people, whose experiences in Africa, we know nothing about? Our history, that is the history of Black Americans, begins after being taken from West Africa, to our experiences in the Caribbean and finally our experiences in the United States. Our language, culture, and religious beliefs have largely if not entirely been developed in the United States. The brutal cruelties of slavery broke our bonds with our specific African lands. We as a people had to, and thus created a culture of Blacks in the United States that enabled us to survive and achieve as a race. Why is it now that we wish to claim ties with a continent that for so long we pushed away? Many would say that it's a sense of pride, a sense of belonging to, and an ability to identify with one's culture. How can we claim culture from a continent? Often times, we as Americans forget that Africa is a vast continent, and get caught up in the

notion of the "mother country." If we're trying to make cultural connections with the continent of Africa, we must also realize that we're trying to make connections with over one hundred different languages, cultures, and religious beliefs. I'm in no way denouncing efforts to understand the history of our African ancestry, in fact I'd applaud it. However, I will question looking to Africa for culture or identity. We can find that here in the United States. Blacks in the United States have shared common experiences and have developed a culture in relation to those experiences. So if it's culture or a sense of belonging and pride that were looking for, then we should be looking to each other. We need to first strengthen the ties and foster unity among Black Americans, then reach out to our Brothers and Sisters in Africa: Remember, we are first American.

## ANNOUNCEMENTS/OTHER

For all those interested, the African Sun is a publication for the expressions of all Black students and organization. You're encouraged to publish essays, poems, announcements, and opinions dealing with the Black commmunity at Brown or in the world. Questions- call 351-9007 or 351-2792.

*George Houston Bass Kulcha Kollectiv* 1st general body meeting, Monday, October 7th at 7 p.m. in the Rites and Reason theater.

*The Next Thing*- interested Third World gays, lesbians, and questioning students-meets Wed. at 9 p.m in Alumni Hall. Questions- call X5883.

*National Society of Black Engineers*-meets Wed. at 7:30 p.m.

## REFERENCES

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